

CONSEQUENCES OF CONTINUING ADDICTIVE LIFESTYLES

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Accept powerlessness over addictive behaviors and the accompanying unmanageability of life and participate in a recovery-based program.
2. Establish and maintain total abstinence while increasing knowledge of the disease of addiction and the process of recovery.
3. Clarify how destructive the negative consequences of substance abuse or other addictive behavior will have to get before they become too bad to tolerate without quitting.
4. Focus attention on the negative consequences of addictive behaviors for self and others.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE SUBSTANCE ABUSE/DEPENDENCE

- Alternative Methods for Managing Pain
- Alternatives to Addictive Behavior
- Balancing Recovery, Family, and Work
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Chronic Pain
- Coping with Addiction and Mood Disorders or Bereavement
- Coping with Addiction and Other Medical Problems
- Coping with Addiction and PTSD or Other Anxiety Disorders
- Coping with Addiction and Thought Disorders
- Early Warning Signs of Relapse
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Identifying Relapse Triggers and Cues
- Making Change Happen
- Personal Recovery Planning
- Planning Aftercare
- Problem Identification
- Relapse Prevention Planning
- Taking Daily Inventory
- Understanding Nonchemical Addictions

- Use of Affirmations for Change
- Using My Support Network
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What Does Addiction Mean to Me?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?
- What's Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Eating Disorders
- Gambling
- Legal Problems
- Occupational Problems
- Opioid Dependence
- Peer Group Negativity
- Relapse Proneness
- Sexual Promiscuity
- Treatment Resistance

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Consequence of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles” activity is intended primarily for clients who are still in denial or ambivalent about giving up addictive behaviors. Its purpose is to increase motivation for entering into and maintaining recovery by breaking down minimization, rationalization, and other defense mechanisms relying on cognitive distortion. Follow-up might include bibliotherapy (e.g., reading personal stories from the book titled *Alcoholics Anonymous* [also known as the *Big Book*] or a book from another appropriate 12-step program) or videotherapy (e.g., viewing and discussing *Clean and Sober* or another appropriate film, including those recommended in the book *Rent Two Films and Let's Talk in the Morning* by John W. Hesley and Jan G. Hesley, also published by John Wiley & Sons).

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This assignment will help you see more clearly what your limits are when it comes to suffering negative consequences of substance abuse or other addictive behaviors. Once you've finished this, it will be helpful to talk about it with your therapist and/or your program sponsor.

1. Have you ever made a *yet list* before, or heard of the idea? _____ A yet list is simply a list of negative consequences of addiction that we know could happen, but which we have not experienced yet. What use would a list like this be to people dealing with addictive behaviors?

2. As you may have heard or figured out, a yet list is used to find your personal definition of being *out of control*. This is a list of experiences you feel would show you that you needed to quit drinking, using, or practicing other addictive behaviors. First, if you truly believed your behavior was out of control, would you quit? _____ Why or why not?

3. Now to make your list: first write down all the negative consequences of drinking, using other drugs, or practicing other addictive behaviors that you can think of that you have *never* experienced. If you have a group to work with, have everyone brainstorm and make a shared list.

4. Now look at this list. Which of these experiences have you escaped through luck (e.g., driving while impaired [DWI] but escaping arrest)?

5. Which experiences have you never risked having happen in your life (e.g., if you never drive while impaired, you've never been in danger of arrest for DWI)?

6. Which experiences from your list of things that haven't yet happened to you would you consider to be definite evidence that your behavior was unsafe or out of control, and why?

7. The experiences you listed for question 6 are your yet list, because they've happened to others but haven't happened to you *yet*. Since you've decided these events would show that your behavior was out of control, what will you do if one of them does happen?

8. If you truly feel that the items on your yet list are unacceptable and would mean you had to quit drinking, using, gambling, or practicing some other compulsive behavior, how do you plan to quit if one of these things does happen as a result of your actions?

9. How can your family, your friends, your therapist, your coworkers, and others you know in some way help you make the commitment to seek help if you experience one or more of the events on your yet list?

10. If you are willing to make a formal commitment to follow through on the decision you wrote about in question 7, how can others help you? What could they do?

11. Who can help you with this? It is a good idea to talk to them ahead of time, now while you're

calm and rational, and explain what you are asking them to do for you. We suggest specifically asking them how they would feel if you came to them for help.

Be sure to bring this handout to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.